and spaces of refuge at a middle distance. He looked over the shoulders of people in prayer, joined across the table a family lighting Shabbat candles, and set foot outside the dedication of a reconsecrated synagogue. Only one image from Berlin depicts an anonymous sitter, and this one departs from his observational style exhibited throughout the rest of the book's public and semipublic spaces. An unnamed elder gentleman in a retirement home is presented with shallow depth of field, suggesting proximity (fig. 1.5). The man sits in an upholstered chair, his elbows craned from padded armrests; his hands form the top of a triangle, and his cane rests below. Next to him two green plants, one larger than the other, grow out of small pots, while a painting of a young man rapt in prayer, draped in a tallit as he solemnly prays, crowns the scene. The relationship between Freed and his elderly subject is complicated by the youthful figure of piety in the painting that hangs above him. If Freed seeks to identify with a figure in the scene, whom is he most drawn to, the old man sitting or the imagined young man praying? Whose role has been surrogated or mirrored, and by whom? The photographer's distance is less physical than social. As Freed gained traction as a photographer in Berlin, he struggled with the city as a space of recovery, identification, and differentiation, finding remnants of its horrific past enlivened by and grappling with stories of survival.

The next time Freed was beckoned to Berlin, it was upon receiving news that the city was being divided. His photographs from August 1961 document the random assortment of construction materials and makeshift barriers that would soon be fortified into a solid wall. In many of his earliest Berlin Wall images, American GIs are the most prominent visual feature, not the Wall. It's as if the Wall had remained outside Freed's immediate field of vision, as he stalked and moved in and out of the borders' spotlighted diplomatic spaces. He viewed the Wall peripherally, with or without American soldiers, or simply not at all. Rather than serving as a vanishing point or visual hindrance to the horizon, the Wall is actually difficult to find in many of these photographs.

Among the GI images is one close-up of three American soldiers with rifles hanging over their shoulders taken within "the first days after the Wall was erected," looking across the street toward a phalanx of opposing eastern troops (fig. 1.6). No part of the border wall is clearly visible. Instead, in this image, the soldiers comprise the immediate foreground. One stands in profile holding his weapon and looking away from the photographer, in